Yasser Nursam Salahuddin Rizal

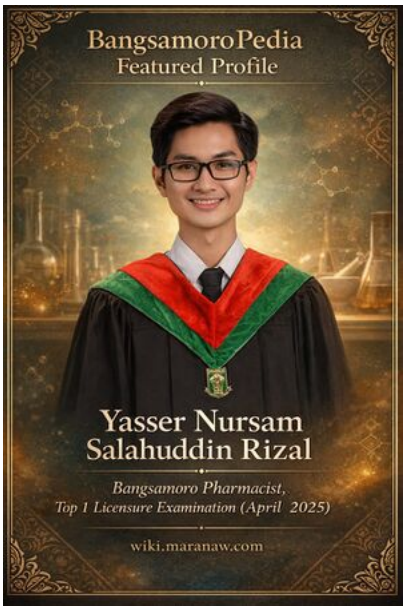
Yasser Nursam Salahuddin Rizal is a Filipino pharmacist and Yakan professional from Basilan who achieved national prominence by ranking first in the April 2025 Pharmacist Licensure Examination administered by the Professional Regulation Commission.

A product of Basilan's educational institutions and the Universidad de Zamboanga, Rizal's top board performance immediately marked him as a symbol of excellence for the Bangsamoro region and a transformative figure for youth from conflict-affected areas of Mindanao.

His success resonates far beyond pharmacy rankings—it challenges long-standing stereotypes about intellectual capacity in marginalized communities and demonstrates that geographic origin and socioeconomic circumstance do not determine professional achievement or excellence.

Throughout his journey, Rizal has consistently attributed his accomplishment to persistent effort, family support, and spiritual faith, making his narrative one of determined resilience rather than effortless privilege.

Yasser Nursam Salahuddin Rizal



Full Name	Yasser Nursam Salahuddin Rizal
Born	Basilan, Philippines
Ethnicity	Yakan
Occupation	Pharmacist
Education	Universidad de Zamboanga (School of Allied Medicine)
Notable Achievement	Top 1, April 2025 Pharmacist Licensure Examination (93.50%)
Religion	Islam
Known For	Symbol of Bangsamoro excellence in pharmacy

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Early Life and Family

Rizal grew up in Basilan, specifically in the communities of Al-Barka and Tuburan, surrounded by educators and healthcare professionals.

His mother, Nihma Salahuddin Rizal, serves as principal of Bangcuang Elementary School, while his father, Jun S. Rizal, teaches at the same institution.

This household environment fostered a culture of academic achievement and professional aspiration from childhood.

Healthcare was woven into his family's fabric—multiple relatives worked as nurses, establishing a tradition of service in allied health professions.

However, it was a maternal aunt already practicing in pharmacy who inspired Rizal to pursue that specific field rather than simply follow the family nursing trajectory.

His early schooling at Geras Integrated School demonstrated his natural aptitude; he graduated as valedictorian and emerged as one of Basilan's promising young scholars.

Rizal himself has described his educational journey as neither a straight path nor an automatic ascent, but rather a process of finding his academic footing and then sustaining momentum.

Education

Secondary Education

Rizal attended Basilan National High School, where he completed both junior and senior high school.

His performance in the Senior High School years earned him valedictorian honors for his batch.

In retrospect, Rizal has characterized his high school experience as a "roller-coaster ride"—a candid acknowledgment that even top performers sometimes pass through periods of self-doubt and recalibration.

He noted that he initially felt like an "average student" before regaining academic momentum, a reflection that humanizes his path to excellence and speaks to the psychological demands of competitive academics.

Higher Education

Rizal pursued pharmacy at the Universidad de Zamboanga (UZ), part of the institution's School of Allied Medicine.

During his college years, he concentrated on mastering pharmaceutical sciences, pharmacology, chemistry, and the regulatory and clinical dimensions of the profession.

His undergraduate performance set a trajectory toward his eventual board exam success, though Rizal has emphasized that preparation for the licensure examination required sustained discipline beyond classroom performance.

He credits his success in part to focused study habits, peer support, and the mentorship of instructors who recognized his potential.

Career and Achievements

The April 2025 Pharmacist Licensure Examination

Rizal's defining professional moment came in April 2025, when the Professional Regulation Commission (PRC) announced the results of the nationwide Pharmacist Licensure Examination.

Among thousands of examinees from across the Philippines, Rizal placed first nationally with a score of 93.50%.

This achievement made him not merely a board topnotcher but the nation's top-ranked pharmacy graduate of that examination cycle.

The announcement generated immediate recognition from government agencies, educational institutions, and community organizations.

The Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) government formally hailed him as a "shining example of excellence" for Bangsamoro youth, framing his achievement as a symbol of the region's intellectual potential.

The National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF) recognized his accomplishment as an inspiring milestone for Muslim Filipinos across the country.

The local government of Basilan province issued formal congratulations, acknowledging that his success brought honor to the entire region.

Significance of the Achievement

For Bangsamoro communities, Rizal's top board ranking holds symbolic weight beyond pharmacology.

He represents proof that excellence in competitive professional fields is not the exclusive province of privileged urban centers or historically advantaged populations.

His achievement directly challenges persistent stereotypes about intellectual capability in regions affected by conflict and marginalization.

For young people in Mindanao considering careers in healthcare and allied professions, Rizal demonstrates that geographic origin does not determine destiny or professional ceiling.

Personal Values and Cultural Significance

On Resilience and Overcoming Doubt

In interviews and public reflections following his April 2025 success, Rizal has been candid about the psychological dimensions of his journey.

He has spoken openly about moments of self-doubt during his academic career, particularly during high school when he questioned whether he could sustain excellence.

> It was not always easy. There were times when I doubted if I could even pass, but I kept pushing because I knew I was carrying the dreams of my family and my community.

This reflection underscores a critical aspect of Rizal's narrative: his achievement was not the product of natural talent alone, but of deliberate persistence even in moments of uncertainty.

He has repeatedly characterized his path as a "roller-coaster ride rather than a fairy tale," deliberately rejecting romanticized narratives of effortless success.

> Success is the result of persistent effort and not just luck.

Identity and Representation

Rizal identifies proudly as both Yakan and Bangsamoro, and he views his professional achievement as a collective triumph for his communities rather than a purely individual accomplishment.

> This isn't just my story or a story of a board topnotcher. This is a story of a son of Basilan. A proud Yakan. A proud Bangsamoro.

His emphasis on geographic and ethnic identity is intentional—it positions his success as evidence that stereotypes about Mindanao and its peoples contradict lived reality.

He has expressed a deliberate mission to challenge limiting narratives:

> I want to show that where you come from does not limit what you can achieve. We in the Bangsamoro are capable of excellence in any field.

Spiritual and Family Foundation

Throughout his reflections on success, Rizal frequently invokes faith as a central pillar of his resilience.

He regularly uses the phrase "Alhamdulillah" (Praise be to God in Arabic), attributing his achievement not solely to personal effort but to divine guidance.

He has spoken about the significance of his parents' prayers and their belief in his potential, especially during periods when he doubted himself.

This integration of spiritual faith and family support reflects values deeply rooted in Islam and in Bangsamoro family culture, where collective prayer and intergenerational encouragement are central to community life.

Mentorship and Advice to Future Professionals

Rizal's messages to aspiring pharmacists and students generally emphasize mastery of fundamentals and consistency over shortcuts.

He counsels students to "master the basics and stay consistent," recognizing that sustained discipline matters more than intensity of last-minute effort.

He also frames the simple act of completing the pharmacy board examination as a genuine accomplishment, reminding students that many who attempt the licensure test do not pass.

For aspiring healthcare professionals from underrepresented communities, he models an approach grounded in faith, family support, peer collaboration, and refusal to internalize limiting stereotypes.

Recognition and Impact

The Bangsamoro Youth Commission has cited Rizal as a "shining example of excellence" whose achievement will "inspire positive change in the region and beyond."

Beyond formal commendations, his success has generated organic grassroots recognition within Bangsamoro communities, where his story circulates as evidence of intellectual capacity and professional potential in populations historically marginalized by national narratives.

Educational institutions in Basilan and across BARMM have referenced his achievement when recruiting students and demonstrating pathways to professional success.

His top board ranking has also influenced discussions within pharmacy programs about curriculum effectiveness, student support systems, and the responsibility of educational institutions to prepare pharmacists capable of serving diverse populations.

Legacy

Yasser Nursam Salahuddin Rizal's significance extends well beyond a single examination score.

He embodies the intersection of personal resilience, family investment, spiritual faith, and regional identity, creating a narrative that speaks to multiple audiences: students considering healthcare careers, Bangsamoro youth navigating systems not designed with them in mind, and Filipino professionals demonstrating excellence in any field.

His willingness to publicly acknowledge doubt and difficulty has proven as influential as his top ranking—it normalizes struggle as a component of achievement rather than a marker of unworthiness.

For the Bangsamoro region specifically, Rizal represents a tangible counter-narrative to conflict-era discourse about "development deficits" or "underdevelopment."

He is living evidence that excellence flourishes in communities with strong family structures, educational institutions committed to student success, and cultural values centered on knowledge and service.

His achievement in pharmacy will likely inspire similar recognition and support for Bangsamoro professionals in medicine, law, engineering, education, and other regulated professions.

As Basilan's first board topnotcher in pharmacy, Rizal has effectively reopened conversations about intellectual representation and who gets positioned as an "achiever" in national professional narratives.

See Also

- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Yakan people
- Basilan
- Universidad de Zamboanga
- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos

- Professional Regulation Commission
- Pharmacy in the Philippines

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